The 36 Stratagems

– Simply Explained –

For twelve-year-olds, with many examples from the schoolyard,
the sports club and everyday life

With Detective Questions and the Fair-Play Rule

The Fair-Play Rule
This knowledge is meant to help you protect yourself and understand situations better. It is not meant for tricking your friends. Anyone who constantly tricks others loses their trust – and that is the worst loss of all.

1. What is this about?

A long time ago, clever people in China came up with 36 tricks. With these tricks you can influence situations – in arguments, competitions or negotiations. These tricks are called **stratagems** (say: stra-ta-jems).

Every trick has two sides, like a mirror:

• **Yang** (say: yang): You use the trick yourself.

• **Yin**: You see through the trick when someone uses it on you, and you know what you can do against it.

Real mastery means being able to do both. And sometimes switching sides – whoever understands how a trick works can also use it themselves.

And the number 72? 36 tricks × 2 sides = 72. That's just maths. There are not 72 different tricks, but 36 that you can look at from two sides.

2. How we look at each trick

1. The idea – what is the core, and how do you use the trick (Yang)?
2. Examples – several scenes from school, sports club or everyday life.
3. Spotting and countering – how you see through the trick and what you can do (Yin).
4. Memory line – a short sentence to remember. It's only a memory aid, not a law.

All names and scenes are made up. Behind each trick, in brackets, is the old name from the book.

3. The six detective questions

Before you react to a trick, always ask yourself these six questions – in this order. The first four help with recognising, the last two with acting. Only when you have answered all six do you decide what to do. That way you don't just jump in when you're angry.

1. Is this really true?
What is only claimed, what is proven? Ask where the information comes from and get a second opinion.

2. What ways out do I still have?
Are options disappearing right now? Always keep a door open, for example a Plan B.

3. Who benefits from this?
(Latin: cui bono) Who gains an advantage if I act this way? Who is steering in the background?

4. Where is my boundary?
What is the other person allowed to do, and what not? Say clearly where you stop.

5. Who is setting the pace?
Don't let yourself be rushed. Set your own deadlines: "I'll answer you by Friday."

6. What will my answer trigger?
Will it make things better or only worse? Quickly play through how the other person might react.

Group 1: Deceiving and Camouflaging (Nos. 1–6)

1. Making everything look completely normal

(Deceive the Heavens to Cross the Sea)

The idea: When something looks completely ordinary, nobody suspects anything – and you can quietly do something special.

Examples:

- Lena says: “I’m just quickly copying the team list, pure routine.” In reality she has put her friends in the starting line-up and dropped another player.
- Tim says: “I’m just tidying the equipment cupboard.” Meanwhile he quietly sorts the best balls into his bag.
- In the class chat someone writes: “Just wondering, who has time today?” – and secretly collects votes for a decision.

Spotting and countering: When someone stresses that it’s “only routine” or “just casually”, look more closely: Who is allowed to decide more than before? Write changes down and check them.

Memory line: *What is camouflage for one person is a warning sign for the other.*

2. Distraction manoeuvre

(Besiege Wei to Rescue Zhao)

The idea: You don’t attack where the other is strong. Instead you put pressure somewhere else so they waste their energy there.

Examples:

- Class 7b makes a huge fuss about a side issue (who fetches the balls). Your team argues about it – and meanwhile 7b quietly poaches your best players.
- During an argument about the break area, one class suddenly starts discussing the broken water tap. While everyone talks about that, they take the better spot.
- Someone distracts in class with a joke – and uses the chaos to quietly take something from the teacher’s desk.

Spotting and countering: Ask yourself: Is the argument really the goal, or is it only meant to distract? Defend what is truly important to you and watch whether anyone is slipping away.

Memory line: *Whoever applies pressure steers attention.*

3. Letting others do the work for you

(Kill with a Borrowed Knife)

The idea: You get other people to do what you want and stay invisible yourself.

Examples:

- Two groups are arguing. Jonas secretly tells each side what the other supposedly said that was nasty. The argument gets heated; Jonas stays out of it.
- Sophie says to Max: “You really have to tell the coach the line-up is unfair.” Max does it – and Sophie gets the place afterwards.
- Someone stirs two friends up against each other and then watches them fight.

Spotting and countering: Ask: Who is telling me this – and what do they gain? Who is steering in the background, who gets the blame? Listen to both sides.

Memory line: *The visible hand is not always the one that steers.*

4. Waiting until the other is tired

(Wait at Ease as the Enemy Tires)

The idea: You save your strength and wait until the opponent is exhausted.

Examples:

- Emre says at every negotiation about the match schedule: “I still need to talk to my team.” After four weeks you are so fed up that you agree to everything.
- When swapping cards someone always says: “Let me think about it a bit more.” After the third time you simply give in.
- A classmate keeps you waiting forever for an answer until you agree out of irritation.

Spotting and countering: Set your own deadlines (“I need an answer by Friday”) and talk to others in the meantime. Ask yourself: Who benefits from it taking so long?

Memory line: *Whoever can wait uses other people’s impatience.*

5. Using other people’s chaos

(Plunder a Burning House)

The idea: When everyone is busy with a problem, you use the situation for your own advantage.

Examples:

- At a tournament a player gets injured. A teammate says: “I’ll step in, but only if I’m captain from now on.”
- While the teacher is talking to another pupil, someone quietly takes the good pen from the desk.
- During a power cut at the clubhouse someone “helps” and rearranges the kits so their clique gets the best ones.

Spotting and countering: Separate “help right now” from “rules for ever”. Solve the emergency first and talk later in peace about new rules.

Memory line: *One person’s crisis is another person’s advantage.*

6. Making noise here, striking there

(Make Noise in the East, Attack in the West)

The idea: You create conspicuous activity in one place so that nobody notices what you are preparing somewhere else.

Examples:

- In the class chat there is suddenly a flood of harmless jokes. Meanwhile a clique quietly plans to drop Selin from the football AG.
- At training everyone suddenly makes a lot of loud fun – and in the background someone is cut from the line-up.
- Someone starts a big discussion about school stuff so that nobody notices they are secretly organising something.

Spotting and countering: Look at what is really happening, not only at the noise. Does what is announced match what people are actually doing?

Memory line: *Whoever steers attention steers decisions.*

Group 2: Tricks against the opponent (Nos. 7–12)

7. Pretending something exists that doesn’t

(Create Something from Nothing)

The idea: You create the impression that something exists (for example a danger) even though it is only claimed.

Examples:

- Ben tells everyone: “We have a secret training programme that will beat you all!” It doesn’t exist – but the other teams get nervous.
- Someone claims: “The teacher said anyone who doesn’t join in is out.” In truth she never said that.
- “Everyone already knows it was you” – even though nobody knows anything.

Spotting and countering: Ask for proof: Show me! When? Where? An announcement is not yet a fact.

Memory line: *Even without substance an impression can have real effect.*

8. Announcing one thing, doing another

(Secretly March to Chencang)

The idea: You openly show one plan but secretly follow a different one.

Examples:

- Class 6a loudly announces: “We’re entering the relay race!” Secretly they train for the obstacle race, where they want to win.
- Someone says: “I’ll help you study.” In reality they only want to copy your notes.
- “We’re only meeting for a kick-about” – and suddenly it’s about a completely different decision.

Spotting and countering: Watch what people do (what they train for, where they put their time), not only what they say.

Memory line: *The visible direction is not always the real one.*

9. Watching while others argue

(Watch the Fire on the Opposite Shore)

The idea: You stay out of it while two others weaken each other, and profit at the end.

Examples:

- Mia and Selin have been arguing for weeks about who should be captain and both are exhausted. Tom stays out – and ends up being chosen by everyone.
- Two friends argue about the same place. You stay calm and get the place in the end because both are fed up.
- In the chat two groups are fighting – and someone who never joined the fight suddenly gets to decide.

Spotting and countering: Ask: Who benefits if we keep arguing? Is the spectator really neutral? Don't keep fighting endlessly; think about who you could win as an ally.

Memory line: *Not every spectator is neutral.*

10. Smiling nicely and having something else in mind

(Hide the Dagger Behind a Smile)

The idea: You are friendly, win trust and still pursue your own goal.

Examples:

- A classmate constantly praises you: "You're the best in goal!" Then they suggest a card swap where they clearly come out better.
- Someone is super nice and invites you – and afterwards asks for something you don't really want to do.
- "You're so cool, can you just help me quickly?" – and later uses your help against you.

Spotting and countering: Separate the feeling ("they're so nice") from the consequences ("what happens if I agree?"). Check agreements carefully.

Memory line: *Friendliness and self-interest can exist at the same time.*

11. Sacrificing something small to keep something big

(Sacrifice the Plum Tree for the Peach Tree)

The idea: You voluntarily accept a small loss in order to save something more important.

Examples:

- The football AG is about to be cancelled. The coach says: "We'll give up one training day so the AG can stay." That is smart.
- Differently: Someone talks you into "You give up your place in the team!" and profits from it themselves.
- When swapping you give away one card so you can keep the much better one – that is fine if you decide it yourself.

Spotting and countering: Ask: Who decides what is sacrificed? Who gains from it? Demand clarity: What do we lose, what do we gain?

Memory line: *Whoever decides what is lost influences what is gained.*

12. Taking small opportunities along the way

(Take the Sheep in Passing)

The idea: You quietly collect many small advantages that nobody notices.

Examples:

- When swapping cards Jonas always says: "Roughly equal is fine." With every swap he gets one extra card. After a month it's a thick pile.
- Someone always "borrows" something for a moment and never quite returns it.
- In every group project someone quietly takes the best task – until in the end they almost do everything alone.

Spotting and countering: Make clear rules ("one card for one card") and watch out for small side deals.

Memory line: *Small losses that nobody notices add up.*

Group 3: Attack (Nos. 13–18)

13. Testing how someone reacts

(Beat the Grass to Startle the Snake)

The idea: You set a small stimulus to see how the other reacts and thereby learn something about them.

Examples:

- Mia casually asks: "Have you got the new kits yet?" She wants to see if the other team gets nervous and how much they know.
- Someone says: "I heard that…" and watches how you react.
- A test comment in the chat just to see who writes what.

Spotting and countering: A provocation is often a test. Don't answer on reflex; decide consciously how much you reveal.

Memory line: *Every reaction reveals something.*

14. Old name, new content

(Lend a Body to a Dead Soul)

The idea: You revive something old in a new form and use a familiar name that everyone trusts.

Examples:

- The “Fair-Play Club” still has the same name as before. But now everyone has to pay money and the rules are completely different.
- “This is still our team” – even though most players and the rules have changed.
- An old chat name is still used even though completely different people are in it.

Spotting and countering: Don’t look at the name; look at what is inside: What is new? What does it cost? What rules apply?

Memory line: *A familiar name guarantees no good content.*

15. Luring the stronger one out of their territory

(Lure the Tiger Out of the Mountains)

The idea: You lure a strong person out of their strong position so that they become weaker.

Examples:

- The best goalkeeper is unbeatable in goal. The opponents call: “Come out, play in the field for once!” Out there they are much worse.
- Someone who is good at maths is pulled into a discussion about something else where they are unsure.
- “Come on, get out of your comfort zone” – and suddenly you are in a situation that doesn’t suit you.

Spotting and countering: Stay in your strength. Ask yourself: Why should I join in there? Does my position become weaker?

Memory line: *In the wrong environment strength becomes weakness.*

16. Letting them go free first so they stay

(Let Escape First in Order to Catch)

The idea: You give the other person a lot of freedom and thereby bind them.

Examples:

- An online game gives you a starter pack with no conditions. Later all your friends are there and leaving would cost you a lot.
- “You can stop any time” – but after a while everything important is there and exit becomes hard.
- Someone gives you a lot of freedom until you are so deep in that you can’t easily get out.

Spotting and countering: Check beforehand: How hard is it to get out again? Keep alternatives open.

Memory line: *Granted freedom can steer you.*

17. Small gift, big return

(Toss Out a Brick to Obtain Jade)

The idea: You give something small in order to get something much bigger.

Examples:

- A classmate gives you a rare card – and then asks if you’ll show them your homework every week until the end of the year.
- “Here, take this” – and afterwards comes the big request.
- A small gift that later becomes expensive because you feel obliged.

Spotting and countering: Calculate the whole price, not just the gift: What do they want for it? How long does it last?

Memory line: *The small value is the price of the large one.*

18. Taking out the most important point

(Capture the Leader)

The idea: You attack the one point that everything depends on.

Examples:

- Only Lena has the key to the ball room. If she is distracted or left out, nobody can get the balls.
- Only one person knows the password for the group chat.
- Only one player can give the tactical signals – if they are out, the organisation collapses.

Spotting and countering: Look at what you depend on and build replacements: a second person with the key, a second admin in the chat.

Memory line: *If everything hangs on one thing, that is a weak point.*

Group 4: When everything is confused (Nos. 19–24)

19. Removing the cause

(Pull the Firewood from under the Cauldron)

The idea: You attack the cause, not the effect.

Examples:

- Instead of constantly arguing about who is to blame for lost matches, the team works on better training – the real cause.
- Someone always complains about the noise but never closes the window that causes the draught.
- The team keeps losing because one position is empty – filling that position solves more than blaming each other.

Spotting and countering: Ask: What is the real cause? Protect your own foundations and look for the root of the problem.

Memory line: *Whoever controls the foundation steers the effect.*

20. Fishing in troubled waters

(Fish in Troubled Waters)

The idea: You use confusion to your advantage.

Examples:

- During a chaotic class discussion someone quietly pushes through a rule that only benefits them.
- While everyone is arguing about the facts, someone decides without anyone noticing.
- Contradictory stories fly around – and in the mess one person gets what they want.

Spotting and countering: Create clarity. Sort out who said what and when. Don't decide while everything is still muddy.

Memory line: *Whoever profits from confusion keeps it going.*

21. Leaving the shell behind

(The Cicada Sheds Its Shell)

The idea: You leave the outer appearance in place while the important part moves away.

Examples:

- The group still has the same name and the same chat – but the real decisions are already happening in a different group.
- Someone leaves the club in name only while the real activity moves elsewhere.
- The "old team" is still talked about, but the important people have already left.

Spotting and countering: Follow the real movements: Who is actually deciding? Where is the real activity?

Memory line: *The visible remains, the essential leaves.*

22. Closing the door to catch the thief

(Shut the Door to Catch the Thief)

The idea: You limit the other person's options so they have less room to manoeuvre.

Examples:

- High switching costs: once you're in a group or app, leaving becomes hard.
- Someone makes sure you only have one way left – and then controls that way.
- "You can only play if you accept these rules" – and the rules keep getting stricter.

Spotting and countering: Secure exit paths early. Check how hard it is to leave before you join.

Memory line: *Control comes from the loss of options.*

23. Allying with the distant, attacking the near

(Ally with the Distant, Attack the Near)

The idea: You team up with someone further away in order to deal with a closer rival.

Examples:

- Two classes that usually don't get along team up against a third class that is stronger.
- You become friends with someone from another year to get support against a classmate.
- Distant allies can change the balance of power.

Spotting and countering: Diversify your own friendships and alliances. Ask what the distant ally really wants.

Memory line: *Alliances also change dependencies.*

24. Borrowing the road to conquer more

(Borrow the Road to Conquer Guo)

The idea: You ask for limited access and then use it for something bigger.

Examples:

- "Can I just quickly use your account?" – and later they still have access.
- Someone is allowed to join training "just once" and then stays and starts deciding.
- Limited permission quietly becomes permanent influence.

Spotting and countering: Keep access narrow, set time limits and write down what was agreed.

Memory line: *Granted access brings influence.*

Group 5: Changing positions (Nos. 25–30)

25. Quietly replacing the supporting parts

(Steal the Beams, Replace the Pillars)

The idea: You change the supporting parts of a system step by step until the whole thing works differently.

Examples:

- Decision rights are shifted little by little until one person almost decides everything.
- The rules of a game are changed one by one until it suits one side.
- Small changes add up to a big shift of power.

Spotting and countering: Watch small changes to rights and rules. Keep a record of what was changed when.

Memory line: *Small changes can alter the whole system.*

26. Pointing at one, meaning another

(Point at the Mulberry Tree, Rebuke the Acacia Tree)

The idea: You criticise or warn one person in order to send a message to someone else.

Examples:

- The coach publicly criticises one player's mistake – but everyone knows the real message is for another player.
- A teacher scolds one pupil as a warning to the whole class.
- Public criticism that is really aimed at someone else.

Spotting and countering: Ask who the message is really for. Don't just react to the visible target.

Memory line: *The visible addressee is not always the real target.*

27. Pretending to be less clever

(Feign Stupidity Without Losing Your Wits)

The idea: You hide your real ability so that others underestimate you.

Examples:

- In a negotiation someone pretends not to understand so that the other explains more and reveals more.
- A player acts unsure and then surprises everyone in the match.
- Underestimating someone can give them room to act.

Spotting and countering: Don't judge ability only by how someone presents themselves. Watch real performance.

Memory line: *Visible ability can differ from real ability.*

28. Removing the ladder after they have climbed up

(Remove the Ladder After the Opponent Has Climbed Up)

The idea: You first make it easy to get in and then make it hard to get out.

Examples:

- A free trial that later makes leaving almost impossible.
- Easy entry into a group, hard exit once you're in.
- Access becomes a trap.

Spotting and countering: Check exit conditions before you join. Secure ways out early.

Memory line: *Access can become a trap.*

29. Hanging artificial blossoms on the tree

(Hang Artificial Blossoms on Trees)

The idea: You create the impression of greater strength or success than is really there.

Examples:

- An impressive demo that doesn't work in real matches.
- Loud self-confidence that doesn't hold up under closer inspection.
- Showing off results that only existed once under perfect conditions.

Spotting and countering: Ask about real performance: How does it work in everyday use, in a real game? What do others who have experienced it say?

Memory line: *The impression of strength is a tool, not proof.*

30. From guest to boss

(Turn from Guest into Host)

The idea: You arrive as a guest and gradually become the one who decides.

Examples:

- A guest player is allowed to join training. After a few weeks they start deciding which exercises you do and who plays where.
- Someone comes "just to visit" and later helps decide.
- The newcomer slowly takes over leadership.

Spotting and countering: Set clear boundaries: A guest remains a guest. Who decides what must stay regulated.

Memory line: *Whoever has access soon determines the rules.*

Group 6: Difficult situations (Nos. 31–36)

31. The feel-good trap

(The Beauty Trap)

The idea: You use feelings: When someone feels especially good or flattered around another person, they check offers less carefully.

Examples:

- The coolest girl in school suddenly invites you into her group, praises you constantly – and then asks for something you don't really want to do.
- Someone softens you up with compliments before making a request.
- Especially with adults or strangers online: If it feels strange, talk to someone you trust.

Spotting and countering: Ask yourself: Would this still be a good offer if it weren't coming from someone so cool? Decide beforehand what is important to you.

Memory line: *Feelings steer decisions.*

32. Acting calm even when you are unsure

(The Empty City)

The idea: You pretend calmness or helplessness so that the other becomes unsure.

Examples:

- You are losing 0–3 and grin relaxed. The other team gets nervous: "What are they planning?" – even though you have no plan.
- Someone stays completely calm even though they are nervous – and you start to doubt.
- "I don't care" – said with a smile that unsettles you.

Spotting and countering: Don't be fooled by the mood. Collect facts instead of guessing.

Memory line: *Uncertainty creates effect.*

33. Turning the spy onto your own side

(Turn the Opponent's Spy)

The idea: You turn someone who is supposed to gather information into your own source of information.

Examples:

- Someone who was meant to report on your group starts telling you what the other side is planning.
- Information from the other side that may not be reliable.
- Always check where information comes from and why it is being shared.

Spotting and countering: Check the source and the motive. Don't rely on a single channel.

Memory line: *Whoever controls information influences decisions.*

34. Injuring yourself on purpose

(Injure Oneself)

The idea: You accept or pretend a disadvantage so that others find you more believable or react in a certain way.

Examples:

- Someone publicly gives up something in order to look principled – and later gains more from it.
- A visible sacrifice that is meant to create trust or pressure.
- Check whether the apparent loss might bring a bigger gain.

Spotting and countering: Look at the real incentives and possible later advantages.

Memory line: *The sacrifice is also a signal.*

35. Chain strategies

(Chain Strategies)

The idea: You link several steps so that together they have a bigger effect.

Examples:

- First build trust, then get access, then influence decisions – one step prepares the next.
- Several small moves that only work as a sequence.
- Don't judge only the single step; look at the chain.

Spotting and countering: Examine each step separately. Don't let a successful first step automatically justify the next ones.

Memory line: *The overall effect comes from the combination of steps.*

36. Retreat as the best strategy

(Retreat as the Best Strategy)

The idea: You withdraw when continuing no longer makes sense, so that you keep your strength for later.

Examples:

- Leaving a hopeless argument instead of fighting to the end and losing everything.
- Switching to a better activity instead of sticking to a losing game out of pride.
- Retreat is not always defeat; sometimes it is smart.

Spotting and countering: Don't automatically read retreat as total victory or total defeat. Ask what it means for the longer term.

Memory line: *Retreat changes the conditions of the conflict.*

7. What this knowledge cannot do

- It does not predict what someone will do. It only shows what is possible.
- It is not proof like in maths; it is a thinking aid.
- The 36 tricks are very old and come from a different culture. The mirror idea is a modern invention.
- Knowledge can be misused. That is why the Fair-Play Rule applies.
- The examples are only examples. Real situations are usually more complicated.

8. What is similar?

- Red Teaming: A group deliberately plays the "opponent" to find weak points.
- Pre-mortem: Thinking beforehand: "Suppose it went wrong – what caused it?"
- OODA loop: Observe, Orient, Decide, Act – like a goalkeeper at a penalty.
- Game theory: Mathematics that calculates how players behave.

9. The most important thing at the end

Each of the 36 tricks has two sides: you can use it and you can see through it. With the six detective questions you proceed calmly before you react. When both sides know the tricks, things can escalate, stop, or lead to a new rule. Stopping is always allowed.

The biggest gain: You no longer read the tricks as a list of mean things, but recognise patterns – and can act early. And the most important thing in all of this is Fair Play.

10. Mini glossary

• **Yang**: Using a trick.
• **Yin**: Recognising a trick and doing something against it.
• **Switch**: Consciously changing sides.
• **Memory line**: Short sentence to remember, only a memory aid.
• **Detective questions**: The six questions before every reaction.
• **Loop**: The back-and-forth when both sides know the tricks.
• **Structure building**: When a new rule grows out of the conflict.

11. Questions to keep talking

1. Can you think of an example from your class or club where one of these tricks appeared?
2. Which of the six detective questions would have been most important there?
3. What would have been a fair response?

Have fun discovering!
And always remember the Fair-Play Rule.